



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: The River Academy
School Website: <https://theriveracademy.org>

December 23, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

River Academy WA 98801 (The River Academy) presents a robust classical Christian education profile. Public materials describe a mission focused on forming virtuous, wise Christian leaders within a Trivium-centered curriculum (Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric) and a strong emphasis on the Great Books/Paideia tradition, integrated with a distinctly Christian worldview. The school explicitly calls itself “Thoroughly Christian, Innovatively Classical, Boldly Joyful, Intentionally Relational,” and frames education as formation of character in a community that partners closely with families. Evidence from core materials highlights: a biblical worldview and statement of faith; a strong Trivium orientation; engagement with primary/Great Books (e.g., Beowulf); commitment to the formation of virtue and character; and liturgical/communal practices such as psalm singing. The school emphasizes community-building elements such as a house system and a relational faculty model, and it actively invites parental involvement as co-educators. Taken together, these signals align most strongly with CLASSICAL, with a notable but smaller emphasis on certain pedagogical practices (e.g., lower-school singing, pastoral relationality) that render one category as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully rigid in every classical rubric detail. Overall assessment: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school presents itself as “Thoroughly Christian” and embeds every subject within a distinctly Christian worldview; the Bible is taught as its own subject, and the community lives out a biblical worldview in learning and culture.
 - Core Values emphasize a Gospel-centered, biblical framework, with explicit language about living out faith through learning.
 - Liturgical/communal expressions appear via Psalm singing and other worship-like practices referenced on site.
 - References to theology/biblical authority are explicit in program materials and faith statements.
 - The Great Books/paideia framing repeatedly ties formation to transcendent realities (truth, goodness, beauty) and a theocentric vision.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology (via biblical authority/worldview); liturgy; worship; psalm; gospel; reverence/wonder (implied in formation language); logos/wisdom (paideia references). Approximately 8–10 positive indicators identified across materials. □filecite□turn0file9□turn0file3□turn0file15□
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident in public-facing materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or “values clarification” signals detected in the visible content).
- Why this rating
 - The materials present a clear transcendental/moral realist frame: real/knowable truths about virtue, beauty, and the good are foregrounded; theology/biblical authority shape curriculum and community life; liturgical practices and communal worship are part of the educational experience.

The strong Christian-theological foundation and liturgical elements align with the Positive keyword indicators for this category, yielding CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The mission centers on forming virtuous, wise Christian leaders who shape culture through faith, wisdom, and joy, not primarily job preparation.
 - The purpose language foregrounds formation, human flourishing, and moral imagination (paideia), not incremental information alone.
 - The site emphasizes truth, the true/good/beautiful, and the formation of a virtuous, thinking person; it also references a long-range, “paideia” view of education.
 - Beowulf/becoming part of the Great Books and the Great Conversation is framed as an avenue to cultivate courage, virtue, and wisdom.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, the pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, long view of education, Great Conversation/Great Books. Estimated count: 6–9 strong signals. [filecite](#)[turn0file6](#)[turn0file9](#)
 - Negative indicators: minimal if any; the site’s stated mission emphasizes formation and virtue rather than job-work preps, though the school is described as “College-Preparatory” in capacity (which is not a negative signal within this rubric).
- Why this rating
 - The school’s stated purpose centers on formation of virtue and wisdom within a classical, liberal-arts frame and a transcendent moral order, aligning with CLASSICAL criteria for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Explicit Trivium framing (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) is central to the program.
 - History is treated as a throughline across the curriculum (and Great Books framing is evident via Beowulf, Plato, Aristotle references).
 - Great Books/Great Conversation references appear in discussions of paideia and classical formation; senior projects and reading lists emphasize primary sources and enduring questions.
 - The curriculum includes classical languages/arts symbolism and a focus on cultivate wonder and memory (e.g., lower-school songs and chants).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators: liberal arts, grammar/logic/rhetoric; great books; historical breadth; paideia; primary sources; memory and wonder. Estimated positives: 6–8 signals. [filecite](#)[turn0file3](#)[turn0file9](#)
 - Negative indicators: limited explicit use of “social studies” framing or overemphasis on secular STEM-first framing; none evident in core materials.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is explicitly grounded in the classical canon (Trivium, Great Books, paideia) with a throughline of history and virtue formation. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL criteria for curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Lower/elementary pedagogy includes singing/chanting and memory work (e.g., Kinder-Prep Psalm singing; regular review and memorization). This aligns with traditional, contemplative/graceful aspects of classical pedagogy.
 - Upper grades emphasize grammar/logic/rhetoric and rhetoric-focused activities (semiotics of the Trivium), which is a hallmark of classical pedagogy.

- There is evidence of relational, mentorship-based teaching and a “living curriculum” feel (faculty as mentors; relational culture).
- The site references Socratic-style activities in upper school logistics (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric pages and senior projects) though explicit “Socratic seminars” language is not consistently visible in all pages.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: singing/chanting, memory work, scholé/restful learning (as implied by contemplative elements and restfulness language), Socratic/seminar/debate in upper school (implied by rhetoric and logic emphasis). Estimated positives: 3–6 signals (including chanting, memory work, rhetoric-focused activities).
 - Negative indicators/signals: explicit, systematic “experiential learning” or fully student-directed, project-based-only pedagogy are not clearly stated; however, there is less explicit documentation of a formal, continuous Socratic seminar program across all grades beyond high school. This creates a partial mismatch with a fully “classical pedagogy” in every grade, hence SOMEWHAT rather than CLASSICAL.
- Why this rating
 - The school embraces several core classical pedagogical elements (Trivium, memory/chanting in early grades, logic/rhetoric in later grades) and a relational, mentoring approach. However, explicit, structured Socratic seminars across all grades and a fully articulated, continuous classical discussion culture are not uniformly documented in public-facing pages. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for pedagogy.

What would move the needle (Pedagogy) - Make explicit, public the full implementation of Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in upper grades (and a clear path to Socratic inquiry from K–12 where appropriate), with documented schedules and example prompts. - Provide clear, public articulation of contemplative/scholé days and memory-work routines across all grades, including specific examples of activities and assessment methods. - Publish a visible, unified description of how projects integrate with the Trivium and Great Books framework (showing balance between memory work and inquiry).

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Core Values emphasize teachers as mentors who form the living curriculum and foster relational, virtuous instruction.
 - The school profiles cite faculty numbers (44) and portray teachers as mentors and living exemplars who guide character formation.
 - House-system, teacher-student interactions and cross-grade mentorship reflect a faculty-centric, relational culture.
 - The publications emphasize long-term teacher formation, mentor relationships, and a portrait of the “teacher as model” within the school.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: living curriculum; mentors; portrait of a teacher; teacher as master/exemplar; collegial culture; teacher-led, relationship-based formation. Estimated positives: 5–7 signals. □filecite□turn0file3□turn0file1□
 - Negative indicators: none clearly evident in public-facing materials (no strong signals of weak or transactional teacher roles).
- Why this rating
 - Materials portray a faculty that embodies the classical ideal of mentors as living curriculum, with strong emphasis on character formation, virtue, and relational pedagogy. This aligns with CLASSICAL for category 5.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- The mission explicitly states partnership with parents as co-teachers and a long-range formation approach.
 - Public materials describe parent formation, reading groups, seminars, and ongoing opportunities for parent involvement and education about classical education (Partnering with Parents content and related blog/notes).
 - The campus invites visits and involvement, supporting open access for parents and families to engage with the school community.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent formation; parent seminars and book study opportunities; open campus/visits. Estimated positives: 5–7 signals. □file-cite□turn0file12□turn0file7□
 - Negative indicators: none evident in public-facing materials (no signals of consumer-centric restrictions or disengagement).
 - Why this rating
 - The public materials emphasize active parental partnership, parental education about classical education, and open invitations for parent involvement, which align strongly with CLASSICAL in this category.

Overall assessment and aggregate ranking

- Classical / Somewhat Classical rubric across the six categories:
 - Element 1: CLASSICAL
 - Element 2: CLASSICAL
 - Element 3: CLASSICAL
 - Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Element 5: CLASSICAL
 - Element 6: CLASSICAL
- Aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: The River Academy exhibits a thoroughly Christian, Trivium-centered curriculum integrated with Great Books/paideia, explicit formation of virtue, and a culture of mentoring and parental partnership. The strongest category signals are Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents/Community. Pedagogy shows clear classical elements but with less explicit public documentation of a fully continuous Socratic/seminar-based framework across all grades, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for pedagogy. The sum of the six categories places the school solidly in CLASSICAL territory.

What Would Move the Needle

- Make explicit, public the full, bindered plan for continuous Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy across K–12 (or clearly state the grade range where it occurs), with sample prompts and outcomes.
- Provide a unified, public articulation of a scholé/restful pedagogy component (days dedicated to contemplation and wonder, with published examples of activities and assessments).
- Publish a formal, cross-grade mapping of how the Trivium is implemented year by year (grammar-/logic/rhetoric milestones) and how Great Books are integrated with the Great Conversation in every relevant grade.
- Expand explicit language on the living curriculum by sharing teacher portraits, teacher professional development plans, and concrete examples of teachers modeling virtue and wisdom in daily practice.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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